Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Edna St. Vincent Millay's "An Ancient Gesture"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion regarding what St. Vincent Millay's poem has to say about the universality of being human, specifically, the universality of being a woman married, and about dealing with troubles include

allusion,
diction,
free verse,
imagery,
literal meaning,
metaphor,
persona,
symbolic meaning,
theme,
tradition, and
tone.

The competitor should recognize Millay's allusion to Penelope's lengthy, patient wait for her husband who has been away at war and Ulysses' being welcomed, once recognized, by his people. The young scholar is being asked to discuss the poem in terms of the universality of being human and the universality of being a woman married, both in terms of dealing with unspecified troubles.

Millay's modern Penelope, the poem's persona, is rather frank about the emotional weight of enduring whatever it is that she endures. The implication seems to be that little recognition comes to the woman of the household. Millay's persona, through allusion, recognizes in her own plight the plight of women historically, and she seems to find solace in the tradition of enduring—whatever it is that women have variously had to endure. She finds specific solace in the tradition of a woman's quietly suffering in the background. The strength of Millay's statement, indeed, the crux, is both that the woman's response is genuine and the man emulates, learns from, the woman. Candor, which might not be so ancient, is all.